



Can we share data about it? What we have started is good, but we have to promote it, share data and be transparent. Now that everyone is aware, we have to make parents aware of it, so that good players come through,” Chhetri says.

“While the federation and States have been working towards improving the women’s game, the speed has been slow. This [qualification] will boost this process as well,” says assistant coach Priya P.V. “We need to improve scouting from the grassroots level. You can find talent in schools, colleges, and even in random pockets. We shouldn’t just stick to professional players because they have the IWL to play in,” adds the former Kerala footballer, who’s been coaching for the past 15 years.

Road to Australia — and beyond

Next year’s AFC Women’s Asian Cup in Australia will be the final edition that serves as a direct

qualifier for the FIFA World Cup. The semifinalists will earn direct qualification for the 2027 tournament in Brazil, while losing quarterfinalists will contest for two additional spots through playoffs. Teams missing out here will still have a final chance via the inter-confederation playoffs.

“I’m showing them dreams here. It’s important because when you have a dream, only then do you work towards it. After the Thailand match, I think everyone has started believing in themselves. We lacked that before,” says Chhetri. The Asian Cup will also act as a qualification route for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, with all quarterfinalists progressing to the second round of qualifiers. On July 11, the AIFF unveiled a ‘roadmap’ to support the team’s preparation for the tournament. This includes an early IWL season (September to January) and an 83-day camp spread over three phases.

Financial boost: The All India Football Federation (AIFF) announced a reward of USD 50,000 (around ₹42.75 lakh) for the Indian women’s team in recognition of its historic qualification for the AFC Women’s Asian Cup 2026.

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The plan envisions “10-12 international friendlies and five to seven matches with domestic teams.

“According to the draw we get, we can dedicate one phase of the camp to each team. By the time the AFC comes, we have a camp of around 40 days and play friendlies against different nations with different playing styles.

“They could be an African country, a European team with a lot of intensity, or even a Latin American team that is very skilled. This will help us adapt to all situations,” Chhetri explains.

The draw will be held on July 29. Until then, the Indian team and its well-wishers can dare to dream about a successful tournament – one that could become a watershed moment for women’s football in the country.

“It’s high time we start supporting them. They should feel wanted. I think we’ll go a long way,” Chhetri concludes.

Pots for draw (world rankings in brackets)

Pot 1	Pot 2	Pot 3	Pot 4
Australia (15)	China (17)	Philippines (41)	India (70)
Japan (7)	South Korea (21)	Chinese Taipei (42)	Bangladesh (128)
North Korea (9)	Vietnam (37)	Uzbekistan (51)	TBD